

CORE FORMULA

Cue -> small move -> pause -> observe -> follow or release. -> Good to see you, Maya. -> You mentioned the presentation — how did it land? -> One name or one detail, used once, then hand the floor back.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Use their name once, or refer to one relevant detail they already shared — then stop and watch the response.

BEST FOR

- When a remembered detail shows genuine care
- When reconnecting after a previous conversation
- When one accurate detail will make the interaction warmer
- Greeting someone by name to set a warm tone
- Picking a relationship back up where it left off
- Building trust across ongoing professional relationships

PHRASE BANK

Greeting by name · Quick openers

- "Good to see you, Maya."
- "Morning, Sam — good to catch you."
- "Priya, good to see you again."
- "Welcome back, James."
- "Nice to run into you, Tom."
- "Alex — perfect timing."

Reconnecting warmly · A remembered detail that shows care

- "You mentioned the presentation last week — how did it land?"
- "I remember you said mornings are easier for you."
- "You had a big week with the move, right? How's the new place?"
- "Last time we spoke you were about to run that first session — how did it go?"
- "How's your dad doing? You'd said he'd been unwell."
- "Did you get to that gig you were looking forward to?"
- "You were deep in exam season last time — is that all done now?"

Work / meeting continuity · Concise, non-performative

- "You flagged the budget as the sticking point last time — where's that landed?"
- "Last meeting you wanted to hold the timeline. Still the priority?"
- "You said the Sydney team owns that call — did you hear back?"
- "I know onboarding was your focus this quarter — how's it tracking?"
- "You mentioned Q3 was tight. Has that eased at all?"
- "Before we start — how did the board session go? You had that Thursday."
- "You'd wanted to loop Priya in on this — shall I hold off until she's across it?"

Checking a detail · Two-option / tentative

- "I may be misremembering, but was today the Sydney meeting?"
- "Correct me if I've got this wrong — you're leading the rollout?"
- "Was it Thursday you were flying out, or have I muddled that?"

- "Remind me — is it Kate or Katie you prefer?"
- "You said fortnightly, not weekly — did I get that right?"

When the detail is off · Softening / release

- "I may be reading this wrong — ignore it if it doesn't fit."
- "Sorry, I've mixed that up. What was it actually?"
- "That was someone else's news, wasn't it? My mistake."
- "We can stay with this or move on — your call."
- "I didn't mean to put you on the spot."
- "Forget I mentioned it if it's not the right time."

Digital / text · One sentence only

- "I may be reading this wrong, but this seems like the relevant thread."
- "Hope the presentation went well on Thursday."
- "Following up on the move — did it all go smoothly?"
- "You mentioned this week was hectic, so no rush replying."
- "Congrats on the launch — I know you'd been building up to it."
- "Thinking of you before the interview tomorrow — you'll do well."

Guarded or high-pressure · Use a detail to ease pressure

- "I know this matters a lot to you — you've said as much before."
- "Last time this came up it was a hard one. I haven't forgotten that."
- "You told me you'd rather be told straight, so I will."
- "You've said before you don't like being managed, so I'll just lay it out."
- "I remember this is the part you were most worried about."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: So, what's new with you?
Better: Good to see you, Maya.
Best: Good to see you, Maya — how did the presentation end up going?
2. Weak: Tell me everything that's happened.
Better: You mentioned the move — how's it going?
Best: You mentioned the move was this week — how's the new place feeling? No need for the full rundown.
3. Weak: You said Thursday. It was definitely Thursday.
Better: Wasn't it Thursday you had the meeting?
Best: I may be misremembering, but was Thursday the Sydney meeting? How did it land?

DECISION TREE

If They add detail

Follow the thread they open.
"Oh — how did that part go?"

If They pause thoughtfully

Wait; don't rush to fill the silence.
"No rush."

If They look uncomfortable

Release the move and ease off.
"Ignore that if it doesn't fit."

If They ask for advice

Switch to permission-based advice.
"Want my take, or just a sounding board?"

If Action is needed

Drop the rapport move and act directly.
"Let's sort the urgent bit first."

SCENARIOS

Casual run-in

Use the minimum move — the name, or one light detail. — "Good to see you, Maya — how was the trip?"

Professional discussion

Keep it concise and non-performative; tie the detail to the work. — "You flagged the budget last time — where did that land?"

Conflict or objection

Pair the remembered detail with validation or an autonomy release. — "I know this matters to you — you've said so before. It's still your call."

Digital message

One sentence only; no stacked questions. — "Hope Thursday's presentation went well."

High-stakes moment

Lead with direct clarity, then use the detail only if it eases pressure. — "Here's where things stand. And I haven't forgotten this one's been weighing on you."

Reconnecting after a gap

Lead with one accurate detail, not a barrage of catch-up questions. — "Last time we spoke you'd just started the new role — how's it settling?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When the detail is sensitive or private
- When it would look strategic or intrusive
- When you are unsure the detail is accurate
- When the person is rushed and needs directness, not warmth
- When physical safety or an emergency takes priority
- When you would be reciting details to prove attentiveness rather than to connect

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Notice what's worth remembering

In three conversations today, catch one detail each worth holding — a name, a date, a preference, or something they clearly care about. Write them down.

Day 2 — Draft the move

For five of those details, write a single line that reuses the detail warmly. Keep each to one sentence.

Day 3 — Weak, better, best

Take one line and write a weak, a better and a best version — escalating from generic, to name-plus-detail, to name-plus-detail-plus-space.

Day 4 — Trim by a third

Cut your best line down by about 30 percent so it feels light and offhand, not rehearsed.

Day 5 — Add the release

Write a recovery phrase for each line, in case the detail turns out wrong or lands oddly.

Day 6 — Use it once, low-stakes

In a real, low-stakes conversation, use one remembered detail once, then stop and watch the response.

Day 7 — Reconnect deliberately

With someone you haven't seen in a while, open by referencing one accurate detail from last time. Notice whether they warm up, and where you'd calibrate next time.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I preserve their autonomy?
- Did I use one detail rather than several?
- Did I watch the response?
- Did I stop when the energy dropped?

- Did the detail feel like care, or like a file note?
- Would a simpler, lighter version have been better?